

to the error, her purse wouldn't lie exposed on the table as a beacon of opportunity to thieves, but safe in her lap.

IMMUNIZE YOURSELF FROM VICTIMIZATION

Stop being a victim by taking responsibility, followed by accountability.

In 2006, I bought my dream home in Phoenix, Arizona, overlooking a gorgeous mountain range. The home had one of the best views in Phoenix but needed a substantial remodel. A new friend recommended a general contractor and I hired the contractor without investigation, no diligence, no reference check, no license investigation, nothing.

Duh. What should have taken eight months rotted into a three-year ordeal, a nightmare that framed the worst decision of my life. The contractor was grossly incompetent and an idiot. Yet, I was to blame. I accepted both responsibility and accountability because I hired the contractor. To plunder a line from *Star Wars*, slightly modified, "Who's the idiot, the idiot himself or the idiot that hires the idiot?"

But I wasn't a victim because I first was responsible: It was my fault. I allowed it to happen. Then, second, I became accountable: Now when I hire house workers, I do an investigation. Or, I could sink my teeth into being a victim and play the pity violin like everyone else.

For my friend with the stolen purse, the Fastlane mindset is to take responsibility followed by accountability. Responsibility: It was my fault that my purse was stolen. Accountability: In the future, I will take precautions to ensure it doesn't happen again.

Immunization for victimitis occurs when you are both responsible for AND accountable to your actions and the possible poor consequences of those actions. Own your mistakes, failures, and triumphs. Reflect on your choices. Are you in a situation because you delivered yourself there? Did you error in the process? Were you lazy? Most bad situations are consequences of bad choices. *Own them and you own your life.* No one can steer you off course, because you are in the driver's seat. And when you own your decisions, something miraculous happens. Failure doesn't become the badge of victimhood—it *becomes wisdom*. Deny accountability and responsibility and the keys of your life are given to someone else. In other words, take the damn driver's seat to your life!

YOU DESERVE! YOU DESERVE! YOU DESERVE!

The other day I heard successive radio commercials that were utterly disturbing. You don't need to be a nuclear physicist to know their target . . . Sidewalking victims.

The first commercial was for a mortgage loan modification company. The sales pitch went like this: "Modify your loan and get the lower payments you deserve." The next commercial was from an attorney. "Been in an accident? Get the money